

# Chapter 3

## Singapore's Pro-natalist Policies: To What Extent Have They Worked?

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Singapore is a pioneer in the Asian region, in terms of both the timing of its fertility decline to ultra-low levels and the timing of introducing policies to counter the trend. While nobody would argue that Singapore has done all that could be done to counter very low fertility, it is unique in the Asian region in terms of the range and scope of its pro-natalist policies.

This chapter outlines the fertility trends in Singapore in comparison with those of other Asian countries currently facing ultra-low fertility, the evolution of pro-natalist policies over the past three decades, and the possible relationship between policies and fertility trends. The chapter attempts to compare the timing and scope of pro-natalist policies in Singapore with policies in other low-fertility Asian countries (in particular, South Korea and Taiwan) and to draw some tentative conclusions about the relationship of policy to fertility in Singapore.

### Fertility Decline in Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan

Like other developing countries, Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan had very high levels of fertility in 1960, the highest of all being South Korea. Japan was in a different league. Its fertility had fallen to low levels far earlier, reaching replacement level in the mid-1950s (Frejka et al. 2010, p. 581). Although the total fertility rate (TFR) in Japan remained low, it was above the replacement level of 2.1 children per woman for a period and then fell below replacement level in 1973. Aside from

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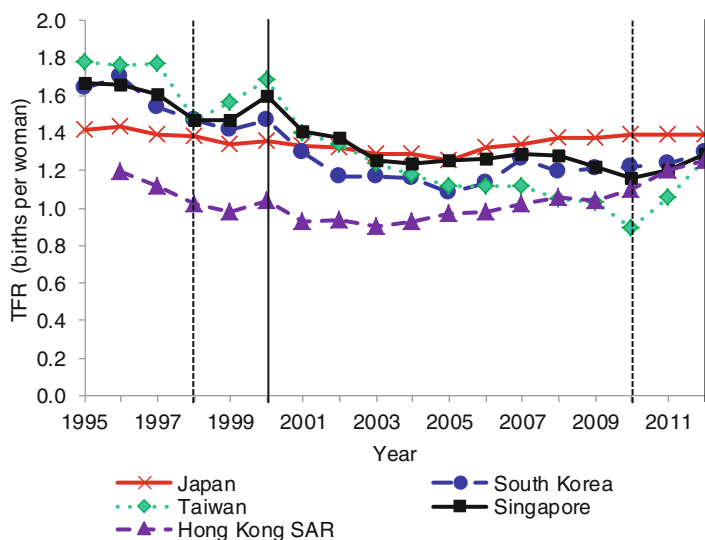
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Japan, Singapore reached below-replacement fertility soonest, in 1975. Singapore had a head start of a few years on Hong Kong and almost a decade's head start on South Korea and Taiwan in this respect. (Both Taiwan and South Korea reached replacement-level fertility in 1983.) From the mid-1980s, however, Hong Kong has been the clear leader in ultra-low fertility.

Figure 3.1 shows the more detailed trends over the past 15 years. If we smooth over the “blip” in TFRs in 2000 due to the dragon-year effect,<sup>1</sup> Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan all experienced considerable fertility decline over the 1997–2003 period, reaching Japanese levels and even going below them. From this 2003 low point (2005 in the case of Japan and South Korea), most of these countries have shown little change, with fertility remaining through and beyond the first decade of the twenty-first century at levels referred to as “ultra-low” by Jones et al. (2009). These are the very lowest levels in the world, although showing a tendency for TFR to rise very slightly. The latest (2012) figures are of course influenced by the latest Year of the Dragon. Too much should not be made of slight year-to-year fluctuations in TFR at these levels, however. While these fluctuations affect annual births, they probably have no effect on a cohort's completed fertility.



**Fig. 3.1** Trends in total fertility rates (TFR) of selected East Asian countries, 1995–2012 (Jones 2007, Table 1) *Note:* Updated from official sources for each country; 1998 and 2010 were Years of the Tiger in the Chinese zodiac cycle, indicated by *dotted lines* in the figure; 2000 and 2012 were Years of the Dragon, indicated by *solid lines*

<sup>1</sup> The Year of the Dragon is considered to be the most auspicious sign of the Chinese twelve-animal zodiac cycle (Saw 1990). The Year of the Tiger (which comes 2 years before the dragon year) is considered inauspicious for births. Dragon years and tiger years are indicated by vertical lines in Fig. 3.1.

## Trend in Singlehood

To understand low fertility in Asian countries we need to understand the changing economic and social conditions in these countries and the way they influence the perceived desirability and feasibility of building a family. The focus is typically on the pressures on married couples, with insufficient attention given to the factors influencing whether people marry in the first place. It is important to understand the reasons behind the marriage trends because marriage is essentially the gatekeeper to childbirth in these societies, with fewer than 2 % of children born outside marriage (Frejka et al. 2010, fn. 10).<sup>2</sup> And in all of these countries, singlehood has been sharply rising over the period of declining and low fertility. It has been estimated that in Singapore over the period 1990–2005, declines in proportions married were responsible for one-third of the decline to ultra-low levels of fertility (Koh 2011).

Figure 3.2 illustrates the rising trend of singlehood at ages 30–34. The trend in this age group is consistent with evidence for other age groups (e.g., 35–39) and with the singulate mean age at marriage (SMAM). Singapore stands out from the other countries in that while its proportion of singles has been increasing, the rise has been much more modest than in South Korea or Taiwan. In 2010, Singapore had the lowest proportion of singles among these countries, for both women and men—a notable reversal of the situation two decades earlier. At ages 30–34, the proportion of single women in Singapore was 25.1 % while the proportion of single men was 37.1 %. Hong Kong and Taiwan are leading the trend in rising singlehood for both men and women. Both South Korea and Taiwan experienced a rapid increase within the 10 years from 2000 to 2010.

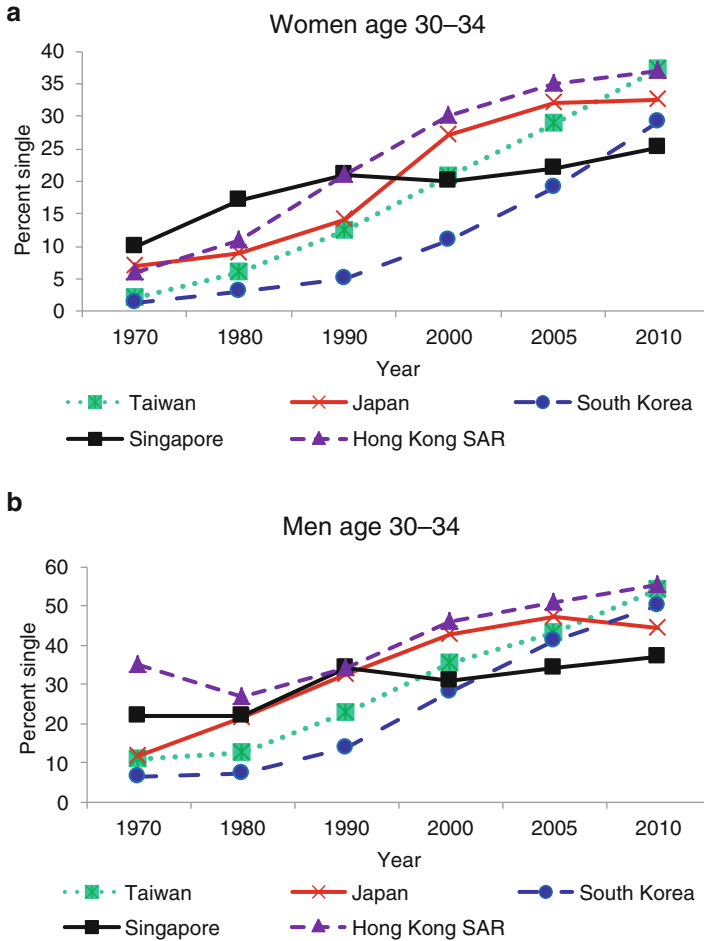
## What Is Driving Trends in Fertility?

In order to assess the likely impact of pro-natalist policies, it is necessary to understand the reasons why fertility has reached such a low level. There is a considerable literature on this,<sup>3</sup> which we will not attempt to summarize in detail here, but we will simply note what appear to be the key reasons in the countries under discussion. These countries are consumerist societies, stressing achievement and upward social mobility above all else (see Chang 2010 on South Korea). They are vastly wealthier than they were four or five decades ago, when parents routinely had four or five children. Nowadays, paradoxically, many feel a sense of relative deprivation, which

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<sup>2</sup>The 2 % figure is in some ways misleading, however, as a considerably higher proportion of births are conceived outside marriage, and the pregnancy precipitates the marriage. These should not necessarily be understood as “shotgun marriages” according to the traditional understanding of this term, as there is evidence, at least from Japan, that many unmarried couples are fairly relaxed about the possibility of a pregnancy and are ready to marry should a pregnancy occur.

<sup>3</sup>For more detailed discussions, see Tsuya et al. 2009; Suzuki 2008, 2009; Eun 2007; Jones 2007; Frejka et al. 2010.



**Fig. 3.2** Trends in proportion single among women and men age 30–34, 1970–2010 (Sources: For Japan, Statistics Japan 2014; for South Korea, KOSIS 2014; for Taiwan, National Statistics 2014; for Singapore, Department of Statistics 2014; for Hong Kong, Census and Statistics Department 2014)

means that aspirations can only be met by both parents working. The financial and opportunity costs of raising children are considerable, particularly as parents face enormous pressure for their children to succeed in education. In this competitive education “arms race,” in the context of limited parental time and financial resources, the “quality/quantity trade-off” comes down heavily in favor of quality.

Strong familism and patriarchy characterize these societies. Economic development and social modernization clash with traditionalism in the household. As a result, women face conflicting roles in balancing work and family life. Access to childcare services is limited, and working women face the tradition of long working hours and a work environment often unfriendly to the need for flexible hours and

childcare leave. These are highly urbanized societies, with long travel times to work coupled with limited and expensive housing to meet the needs of larger families.

Given the many dilemmas that are part and parcel of marrying in these societies (the notion of a “marriage package,” as described by Bumpass and colleagues (2009) in Japan, is equally relevant here), it is small wonder that there is increasingly later and less marriage. Aside from volitional reasons, non-volitional factors are also operating, including the inadequate replacement of traditional matchmaking systems, and continued hypergamy and homogamy, leading to a marriage squeeze for certain groups. The combination of a rise in age at marriage, a situation where 15 % of women will be permanently removed from the reproductive population by non-marriage (probably within 10 years), and continuing high levels of divorce bodes ill for any substantial rise in fertility. Furthermore, there is little indication of a trend toward more cohabitation, and even less so of acceptance of child-bearing in cohabiting relationships—trends that have propped up fertility rates in many Western countries.

## **Policy Development: Singapore's Switch from Anti-natalism to Pro-natalism**

Singapore achieved self-government in 1957, entered the Federation of Malaysia in 1963, but left the Federation to become a separate, independent state in 1965. Facing very high fertility levels combined with uncertainties about the political and economic future of what was considered an over-populated island, the government introduced a national population-control program, passing the Singapore Family Planning and Population Act in 1965 and establishing the Singapore Family Planning and Population Board in 1966. A series of anti-natalist measures were introduced, including the Voluntary Sterilization Act in 1969, as well as a set of incentives and disincentives to encourage small families in 1972. Some of the measures introduced and implemented during the anti-natalist period included the reduction of income tax relief to cover only three children, lowering of priority for primary school admission for fourth-order and above children, elimination of the housing subsidy for large families, and limitation of paid maternity leave to first and second births (Sun 2012, p. 63).

The pace of fertility decline that followed was one of the most rapid in the world. It was widely attributed to the anti-natalist policies, although many other factors were clearly involved. Although Singapore's fertility reached replacement level in 1975, the anti-natalist policies were kept in place until 1983. Then in 1984, the state implemented selective pro-natalist policies, described as the “eugenic phase” of Singapore's population policy. Educated women were given incentives to reproduce under the “Graduate Mother Scheme,” while sterilization cash incentives were offered to less educated women (Straughan et al. 2009, p. 184; Saw 2005, p. 212). These policies proved to be very unpopular with broad sections of the public. They

were abandoned in 1985, followed by the closure of the Singapore Family Planning and Population Board in 1986. The following year (1987), the fertility policy in Singapore took on a broadly pro-natalist stance, with the introduction of both slogans and policies to support having three or more children based on affordability. This stance has shaped Singapore's fertility policy until the present, with various policies to increase fertility introduced and strengthened over the years.

There was an interval of 15 years between the time fertility first dipped below replacement level and the introduction of pro-natalist policies directed at the population as a whole. As the pioneer in fertility decline in the region, with a history of strong and effective anti-natalist policies, it is perhaps not surprising that there was hesitation to reverse these policies until it was clear that no resurgence in fertility was likely. The subsequent history of policy reversals in other Asian countries shows that Singapore was no exception in delaying its policy reversal (see Table 3.1).

**Table 3.1** Delays in reversing anti-natalist policies, selected East Asian countries

| Country     | Year in which replacement fertility was reached | Year in which anti-natalist policy was reversed | Number of years elapsed | Percent below replacement when policy reversed | Comments                                                                                                   |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Singapore   | 1975                                            | 1984                                            | 9                       | 25                                             | Selective pro-natalist policies for highly educated                                                        |
| Singapore   | 1975                                            | 1987                                            | 12                      | 25                                             | More general pro-natalist measures                                                                         |
| South Korea | 1984                                            | 1996                                            | 12                      | 20                                             | Very mildly pro-natalist policies                                                                          |
| South Korea | 1984                                            | 2004                                            | 20                      | 50                                             | More serious pro-natalist measures                                                                         |
| Taiwan      | 1984                                            | 1992                                            | 8                       | 20                                             | Pro-natalist statement but no measures                                                                     |
| Taiwan      | 1984                                            | 2006                                            | 22                      | 47                                             | Specific pro-natalist measures introduced                                                                  |
| Japan       | 1973 <sup>a</sup>                               | 1990                                            | 17                      | 25                                             | Mildly pro-natalist measures                                                                               |
| Japan       | 1973                                            | 1994                                            | 21                      | 32                                             | Angel plan introduced in 1994, revised in 1999; more forceful pro-natalist measures                        |
| China       | 1992(?)                                         | No reversal                                     | 21+                     | n.a.                                           | 25–30 % below replacement in 2013; policy modified to allow only child to have two children after marrying |

<sup>a</sup>Japan's TFR was slightly below replacement level as early as the 1950s, but it hovered around that level for two decades and did not fall definitively below replacement level until 1973

## The Development of Singapore's Pro-natalist Policies

Policies emphasizing larger families and early family formation were implemented during the late 1980s to the late 1990s. Some of the measures and incentives that were introduced included subsidized childcare, tax rebates for third children, and public housing schemes encouraging early family formation and larger families, such as the Fiancé/ Fiancée Scheme, the Parenthood Priority Scheme, and other schemes for first-time married couples.

Then, in 2000, the government introduced a number of new policies and revisions. Importantly, the Baby Bonus Scheme was introduced. This two-tiered system involved distribution of cash benefits on the birth of second and third children. It also included a co-savings arrangement set up by the government, which was payable over a 6-year period, with maximum contributions capped at S\$6,000 for the second child and S\$12,000 for the third child.<sup>4</sup> This co-saving could be used for all children. Tax rebates, which were offered only to the third child in 1987 and to the third and fourth child in 1989, were extended to include the second child. Singapore's total fertility rate (TFR) continued to decline from 2001 to 2003, however, despite the introduction of these and a variety of other incentives aimed at encouraging marriage and childbearing. The TFR fell from 1.61 children per woman in 1997 to 1.25 in 2003.<sup>5</sup>

In 2004, the Baby Bonus Scheme was extended to include the birth of first and fourth children, when S\$3,000 and S\$6,000 were given to parents. This cash gift was distributed in five instalments over an 18-month period as opposed to over 6 years previously. In 2008, the payout to first and second children was raised from S\$3,000 to S\$4,000.

Since 2003, Singapore's TFR has stayed in the 1.2 region, with minor changes until 2010, when it fell slightly lower to 1.16. This could be because 2010 was a Year of the Tiger, which is considered to be inauspicious for birth in the Chinese zodiac cycle. In the following year, the rate rose marginally to 1.20 and in 2012—a Year of the Dragon—it went up to 1.29 (see Fig. 3.1).

Policies were further boosted in January 2013 in the form of a Marriage and Parenthood Package, aimed at helping Singaporeans “to form families and raise children” (NPTD 2013a). This enhanced package includes giving priority in the assignment of a first-time public-housing apartment to couples who have children. It also includes enhancing Co-Funding for Assisted Reproduction Technology (ART) Treatment, waiving accouchement fees in public hospitals to all mothers irrespective of the birth order of the child, extending paid childcare leave, and introducing paid adoption leave, 1 week paid paternity leave, and shared parental leave (see [Appendix](#) for details of policy enhancements).

<sup>4</sup>All dollar figures in this paper are in Singapore dollars. In 2013, S\$1 = US\$0.80.

<sup>5</sup>There was a blip to 1.60 in the 2000 Year of the Dragon—up from 1.47 in 1998 and 1999.

## Categories of Pro-natalist Policies in Singapore

McDonald (2002), citing Heitlinger (1991), categorized fertility policies under:

1. Financial incentives
2. Support for parents to combine work and family
3. Broad social change supportive of children and parenting

Policies to influence marriage are not specifically included here. Although marriage is affected by fertility desires,<sup>6</sup> thus being affected by all the above elements of fertility policy, there are other factors influencing whether people marry. One way to think of factors affecting marriage is to divide reasons for not marrying into volitional and non-volitional categories. Singapore has had specific policies to influence marriage, and the government clearly considers marriage policy important in its armory of policies to influence fertility. Marriage policies will therefore be included as a fourth type of pro-natalist policy.

### *Financial Incentives*

Lump-sum payments or loans, tax rebates, subsidized or free services and goods for children, and housing subsidies fall under the category of financial incentives. Singapore has implemented all four of these types of policy. With the introduction of the two-tiered Baby Bonus Scheme in 2000, the Singapore government began offering cash payments to parents. In 2013, the amount offered was increased to S\$6,000 (up from S\$4,000 previously) for the birth of a first or second child and S\$8,000 (up from S\$6,000 previously) for the birth of a third or fourth child. The cash grant is given only through the birth of the fourth child. It is now fully disbursed earlier, within 12 months of the child's birth as compared to 18 months previously.

The scheme also involves setting up a Child Development Account (CDA), which is essentially a co-savings arrangement between parents and the Singapore government. When it started in 2000, only second and third children were eligible, and the duration of the CDA was 6 years. Since 2008, the government will match dollar-for-dollar the amount saved by parents for first- and second-born children, up to a maximum of S\$6,000 each. For third- and fourth-born children, the government contribution is capped at S\$12,000 each, and for fifth-born children and beyond, the contribution is capped at S\$18,000 (Ministry of Social and Family Development 2013). In 2013, the duration of the CDA was extended for another 6 years, enabling parents to receive matching contributions until a child turns 12, but the maximum levels of government contributions remain unchanged.

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<sup>6</sup>Indeed, Raymo (2003) has argued in the case of Japan that changes in the desire for children are more important in understanding marriage behavior than changes in the desirability of marriage itself.

Singapore also offers tax rebates for working mothers and various housing-subsidy schemes (see [Appendix](#) for details). The government does not offer much in the way of free or subsidized services or goods for children, however. Services include education, dental and medical care, while goods could include textbooks or leisure and sporting equipment (McDonald 2002, p. 437).

In early 2013, Singapore introduced a Medisave Grant for newborns. Medisave falls under the Central Provident Fund (CPF). Under this scheme, a CPF Medisave account is opened for each newborn citizen, and a Medisave grant of S\$3,000 is deposited. The first S\$1,500 is deposited after birth registration, and the remaining S\$1,500 is deposited in the subsequent year, provided that the child remains enrolled in MediShield or a Medisave-approved Integrated Shield Plan.

### ***Support for Combining Work and Family***

Under the category of support for combining work and family, McDonald (2002, pp. 438–42) listed childcare, flexible working hours, anti-discrimination legislation, and gender equity in employment practices. Singapore increased paid maternity leave from 8 to 12 weeks in 2004 and from 12 to 16 weeks in 2008. In 2013, the government introduced a 1-week paternity leave and allowed the father to take an additional week out of his wife's 16-week maternity leave under a new "Shared Parental Leave" scheme. Paid adoption leave of 4 weeks was introduced in 2004 and made mandatory in 2013. In order to facilitate alternative childcare arrangements, the government offers grandparent caregiver relief, domestic worker levy relief, and childcare subsidies. A 5-day work week was introduced in 2004 for government-employed civil servants, although total working hours were held constant, thus requiring extended working hours on the five working days (see [Appendix](#) for details of policies).

### ***Broad Social Change Supportive of Children and Parenting***

Under broad social change supportive of children and parenting, McDonald (2002, pp. 440–42) listed employment initiatives, child-friendly environments, gender equity, marriage and relationship supports, followed by development of positive social attitudes toward children and parenting. Singapore introduced the "Work-Life Works" Fund in 2004, under which private-sector firms can apply for grants to defray the cost of introducing measures that would help employees achieve better work-life harmony. Although this was a good introductory move, the implementation is left largely to the employers' discretion. In light of other opportunity costs and market considerations, it might not necessarily be in the interest of competitive private companies (especially small and medium enterprises—SMEs) to implement this new program.

## *Marriage Policy*

Rising singlehood has been one of the major direct causes of fertility decline in Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, and Singapore. Singlehood is particularly high in cities and for well-educated women. In the younger adult ages, there are now few women with primary-school education or less, so the key comparison is between the high-school and tertiary educated. In all four countries, delayed and non-marriage is considerably higher for tertiary-educated women.

As early as 1984, Singapore had identified rising singlehood, especially among its well-educated women, as an issue to be addressed and began setting up agencies to provide match-making services. The services and range of activities offered through the Social Development Network (SDN) are now varied, sophisticated, and Internet-based. Services include personalized matchmaking, overseas trips, and engagement with the private sector through accreditation of dating agencies.<sup>7</sup> It is difficult to assess whether the claims for success of the SDN are well justified, however. Statistics published to indicate that a substantial number of Singaporeans who were registered with the SDN eventually married cannot address the counterfactual—how many of these people would have married anyway in the absence of the government's programs (Jones 2012, p. 324)?

The two other key ways in which Singapore has influenced the incidence of marriage are through housing policy and the policy on granting Permanent Residence (PR) status. Singlehood is discouraged by eligibility rules for Housing and Development Board (HDB) apartments, in which about 85 % of Singaporeans live. Singles must be over 35 to be eligible to purchase this form of subsidized housing. Also, various housing inducements are offered to Singaporeans planning to marry, all of them directed toward shortening the waiting time for apartments or widening the scope for this group to buy or rent an apartment (for details, see Jones 2012, pp. 323–4). As for PR status, permanent residents in their 30s are twice as likely to be married as Singapore citizens, suggesting that the government's criteria for approval of permanent-residence applications may, in part, be aimed at raising the proportion married (Jones 2012, p. 325).<sup>8</sup>

One point should be made about policy developments in Singapore. The government has consulted the public widely, particularly in recent years, before introducing changes in family policy. The National Population and Talent Division, which is now responsible for population policy, had a program of wide community consultation before introducing the new measures in 2013. Sociologist Paulin Straughan, who also served a term as an appointed Member of Parliament, noted that the new measures gave a message to the Singapore population that the government prizes a pro-family and gender-equal environment as much as it does a competitive, business-

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<sup>7</sup>Details of the range of services offered can be found at <http://app.sdn.sg/DatingServices/OnlineorPersonalisedMatching.aspx>.

<sup>8</sup>Citizens and permanent residents together make up the resident population, which is the denominator for the calculation of Singapore's demographic rates.

friendly climate. One intention of the policies, she said, “was to set the ideological tone, to say very boldly that the government stands behind family formation” (Chang 2013).

## **Timing and Nature of Policies: Comparison between Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan**

It is interesting to take a cross-sectional snapshot of fertility policies in the region as of 1995. Keep in mind that fertility rates in 1995 were well below replacement level in Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan and at ultra-low levels (TFR below 1.5) in Japan. Singapore had begun promoting the formation of families in 1987, and by 1995 Singapore had more pro-natalist policies in place than the other countries. In fact, it had been 8 years since the Singapore government had introduced income-tax relief, tax rebates, childcare subsidies, and housing subsidies for larger families. By the early 1990s, housing incentives to encourage early family formation included HDB's Fiancé/Fiancée Scheme, under which couples intending to marry could register for an apartment together and marry within 3 months of taking possession. This scheme aimed to enable couples to have a ready home upon marriage. In 1990, the Domestic Worker Levy Relief was introduced to encourage working mothers to continue working while having someone to take care of their child. Despite all these pro-family and pro-fertility measures, however, fertility continued to decline.

Both Taiwan and South Korea reached replacement level fertility in 1984 but by 1995 had no pro-natalist policies in place. The Taiwanese government had made a pro-natalist statement but had not introduced any concrete measures. It was only in 2006 that both Taiwan and South Korea implemented their respective pro-natalist policies.

The South Korean government was very slow to reverse its anti-natalist policies. In 2002, the Noh Mu-Hyeon government took a step toward initiating pro-natalist policies, but it took a few more years for the policies to actually be implemented. At this time, South Korea's TFR was the lowest in the world, declining in 2005 to 1.08 (Lee 2009, p. 57). It was only in 2006, however, that the South Korean government announced an integrated package, the “Saeromaji Plan 2010,” which comprised a variety of pro-natalist measures (Suzuki 2008, p. 37). These measures included tax rebates, expansion of maternity and childcare leave, and improvement of childcare services. South Korea was not able to offer a universal child allowance, however, due to budget constraints.

Taiwan's TFR started declining gradually from 1995, but in the 1998 Year of the Tiger, it declined drastically—to 1.47 from 1.77 in 1997. Beside the Year of Tiger being inauspicious for birth, the financial crisis of 1997 also contributed to this decline. In the following 2 years, the TFR rose slightly, then declined sharply again in 2001, to 1.40 from 1.68 in 2000. Following this decline, Taiwan's TFR has declined consistently, with the exception of the years 2005–2007 when it remained at 1.12. In the 2010 Year of the Tiger, Taiwan's TFR plunged to 0.89, probably

the lowest level of fertility ever reached in any country with a population in excess of ten million. As in South Korea, Taiwan had no pro-natalist policies until 2006, when measures such as maternity and parental leave and a childcare subsidy system were introduced under the “Mega Warmth Social Welfare Program” (Freijka et al. 2010, p. 599). This was followed by the 2008 White Book of Population Policy. Since the introduction of these measures, the TFR has yet to increase significantly, although the increase to 1.26 in the 2012 Year of the Dragon raises hope that the inevitable subsequent decline will still leave fertility somewhat higher than it was before.

Clearly Singapore was a little faster than Taiwan or South Korea in reacting to a fertility decline and beginning to reverse its anti-natalist policies. But now that both South Korea and Taiwan have had pro-natalist measures in place for some years, it is worth comparing the similarities and differences between their policies, those of Japan, and those of Singapore. Singapore’s policy of financial incentives has been expanded over time and now is clearly the most comprehensive among the four countries. On the birth of a child, Japan offers a cash payment of 10,000 yen (roughly US\$100) monthly until the child turns three. The Japanese government does not offer large tax deductions for children, however (Frejka et al. 2010, p. 598). Neither Taiwan nor South Korea offers cash payments, the former due to feminist protests and the latter due to budgetary constraints, although South Korea has lower taxes for large families or families with young children.

In terms of support for combining work and family, Taiwan provides paid maternity leave up to 8 weeks, with 70 % of the cost payable by the employer (Frejka et al. 2010, p. 600), and 3 days of paternity leave. South Korea offers 12 weeks of paid maternity leave and 3 days of paternity leave. Paternity leave is not paid by the government, however, but is left to the discretion of employers. Again, Singapore’s policy is more comprehensive, with longer paid maternity leave and (since early 2013) more paternity leave.

Both Taiwan and South Korea have enhanced their support for childrearing with improved childcare subsidies and provision of high-quality childcare. Singapore also subsidizes center-based infant care and childcare, differentially for working and non-working mothers. Its policy is complicated by the fact that “childcare” and “pre-school education” are related but have somewhat different goals. Singapore also offers grandparent caregiver relief and reduced maid levy to help working mothers who rely on grandparents or maids for infant and childcare.

Singaporean families with two or three children can now expect to receive significant financial incentives as a result of the overall package offered by the government. Indeed, the National Population and Talent Division gave an estimate in early 2013 that a family with two children can enjoy benefits of about S\$100,000 in baby bonus payments, Medisave grants for newborns, infant care and childcare subsidies, and tax savings by the time both children turn 13. If the value of paid maternity and paternity leave and paid childcare leave is added in, the total benefits sum to about S\$166,000. This estimate excludes housing subsidies and the equivalent of S\$12,000 in additional tax savings beyond the children’s first 13 years. While substantial, these figures need to be compared with rough estimates that the total finan-

cial cost of having a baby and raising it to age 18 is somewhere between S\$250,000 and S\$350,000, depending on choices on schooling and life style (Cheam 2013), or between S\$500,000 and S\$700,000 for two children. Beyond age 18, university fees add considerably to that cost (Tan 2010). Thus the common comment of young Singaporeans—that the government support is much appreciated but that it will probably not be a major factor in their decision on whether to have children—makes sense, although it may reflect a lack of appreciation of just how substantial government contributions are, in fact offsetting as much as one-third of the cost of raising a child to age 18.

When considering policies under broad social change supportive of children and parenting, Singapore, Taiwan, and South Korea could all go further by introducing more flexible working hours, anti-discrimination legislation, and gender equity in employment practices. Singapore has taken steps toward these goals with the introduction of paid paternity leave in 2013. Singapore also seems to be the only Asian country actively promoting marriage and early family formation through its subsidized match-making services and housing subsidies.

All the countries discussed here seem to be promoting the development of positive social attitudes toward children and parenting in various ways. The big question is how these societies will be able to overcome deeply entrenched societal pressures and expectations that work against family formation. One of these is the strong pressure on parents to raise quality children through intensive parenting, supplementing what the school can do by providing coaching, extra-curricular activities, and parental assistance with homework. Awareness of these pressures is leading some people to avoid having children or to have only one or two (e.g., see Anderson and Kohler 2013).

## **Singapore Realities: Childrearing Issues Facing Working Mothers**

Government policy to influence fertility must deal with the reality that most married couples in Singapore expect both wife and husband to work. Many wives feel the need to return to work as soon as possible after the birth of a child. This is facilitated in many cases by foreign domestic workers (who are employed in about one in six Singapore households)<sup>9</sup> or grandparents assuming responsibility for childcare. Where these two possibilities are not available, however, paid childcare is the only option. Although subsidized for Singapore citizens, paid childcare still represents a financial burden, especially for low-income households. It also forces mothers to choose between not working and leaving their young children in childcare for long hours because there are very few workplace-based childcare facilities.

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<sup>9</sup>These workers are on fixed-term contracts and are mainly drawn from the Philippines and Indonesia, with smaller numbers from Myanmar and Sri Lanka. Lower-income families cannot afford the cost of employing a domestic worker.

Working hours are typically long, and there are relatively few part-time work opportunities. In June 2012, among the resident population, fewer than 10 % of those employed worked less than 34 h a week. The average number of hours worked per week was 45.6 among all employees and 48.2 h among full-time employees (Ministry of Manpower 2012, Table 5). The average cost for a full-day infant-care program (up to age 18 months) has increased from S\$1,206 a month in 2008 to S\$1,376 in late 2013. The average cost for a childcare program has increased from about S\$699 a month in 2008 to S\$1,000 a month in early 2014. Working mothers with a monthly family income of less than S\$7,500 can receive subsidies of S\$600 per month toward the cost of infant care and S\$300 per month towards the cost of childcare. This still leaves a substantial gap to be paid by the parents, which would be felt particularly by low-income families earning less than S\$3,000 a month.

Working mothers face many issues even after their children enter primary school. The mismatch between working hours and school hours is obvious. Normal primary-school hours in Singapore are from 7.30 a.m. to 12.30 p.m. (although in some of the older schools there is a separate afternoon shift). Extra-curricular activities may keep the child at school for some additional time. After that, if there is nobody at home, the parents will have to make separate arrangements for their children's care, sometimes available in school-based student care centers (which cater for students age 7–14 and charge about S\$260 per month) and sometimes in community centers.<sup>10</sup> Students can stay at these centres until 6:00 or 7:00 p.m.

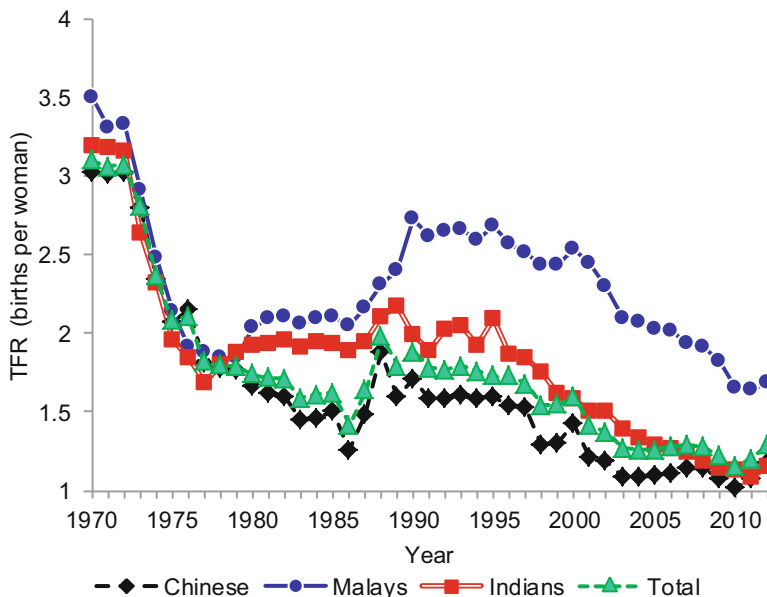
A litany of stresses on a working mother can be cited: arranging infant care; waking before daylight to get children off to school; making arrangements for after-school care, coaching, and other after-school activities; helping with homework; arranging leave to care for sick children or to take them to the doctor; and dealing with expectations from other parents for intensive childrearing that leads to academic success.

## **Has Singapore Shown Any Signs of Doing Better in Fertility Recovery Than Other Countries?**

Singapore's population reached replacement fertility in the mid-1970s, whereas fertility in Hong Kong, South Korea, and Taiwan declined to this level in the 1980s. Among these countries, Singapore led in the implementation of pro-natalist policies and has gone further than other countries in many policy areas. We might expect, then, to see more impact on fertility. There have been no more signs of fertility recovery in Singapore, however, than in the other countries. Indeed, Singapore has not matched Japan, Hong Kong, or South Korea in showing slight increases in TFR in recent years. This is partly because the fertility of the Malay population, who

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<sup>10</sup> Low-income families can apply for financial support for this.



**Fig. 3.3** Trends in total fertility rate (TFR) by ethnic group, Singapore, 1970–2012 (Department of Statistics 2009, 2013)

account for about 14 % of the total, fell quite sharply from relatively high levels over this period (see Fig. 3.3).

Given Singapore's physical size and bearing in mind that it is a city-state, comparisons with other cities in the region may be more appropriate than comparisons with other countries. When compared with other cities, Singapore does not fare badly. Singapore's TFR is roughly 10–25 % higher than that of Tokyo, Seoul, Busan, Taipei, Kaohsiung, or Hong Kong (Table 3.2; see also Jones 2012). The contrast with Beijing and Shanghai, where TFR is well below 1, is even greater. However, these city-to-city comparisons are also problematic in some ways. As a city-state, Singapore can control immigration in a way that the other cities cannot. Fertility in the other cities might be held down by selective in-migration of those who are less interested in having children or who intend to postpone childbearing until they have returned home.

It is difficult, if not impossible, to test the effects of various pro-natalist measures on Singapore's fertility, but two alternative assumptions might be used to set some kind of extreme limits on their likely impact. The first would be that, because there has been no clear increase in TFR since policy measures were strengthened in 2004 and 2008, the policies have had no impact. The second would be that in the absence of the policies, fertility would have declined even lower than it did. One hypothesis would be that without the policies, fertility would have been at much the same level as that of other major cities in East Asia—Tokyo, Seoul, Busan, Taipei, and Hong

**Table 3.2** Singapore total fertility rates (TFRs) compared with those of other large cities in East Asia

| City                     | Average TFR<br>2008–2012 | Ratio of<br>Singapore TFR to<br>TFR in this city | Ratio of Chinese<br>Singaporeans' TFR<br>to TFR in this city |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Singapore                | 1.23                     | –                                                | –                                                            |
| Singapore (Chinese only) | 1.10                     | 1.12                                             | –                                                            |
| Beijing <sup>a</sup>     | 0.71                     | 1.73                                             | 1.55                                                         |
| Shanghai <sup>a</sup>    | 0.74                     | 1.66                                             | 1.49                                                         |
| Tokyo <sup>b</sup>       | 1.10                     | 1.12                                             | 1.00                                                         |
| Seoul                    | 1.01                     | 1.22                                             | 1.09                                                         |
| Busan                    | 1.04                     | 1.18                                             | 1.06                                                         |
| Taipei                   | 1.08                     | 1.14                                             | 1.02                                                         |
| Kaohsiung                | 0.93                     | 1.32                                             | 1.18                                                         |
| Hong Kong                | 1.13                     | 1.09                                             | 0.97                                                         |

*Sources:* For Singapore, Department of Statistics 2014; for Beijing and Shanghai, National Bureau of Statistics of China 2014; for Tokyo, Statistics Japan 2014; for Seoul and Busan (2008–2012), KOSIS 2014; for Taipei and Kaohsiung, Ministry of the Interior, Republic of China (Taiwan) 2014; For Hong Kong, Census and Statistics Department 2014

<sup>a</sup>2010 estimate, from 1 % sample of the 2010 Population Census

<sup>b</sup>Tokyo Prefecture; for Central Tokyo (ku-bu), the TFR is 1.08

Kong (but not Beijing or Shanghai, since their fertility is strongly influenced by China's one-child policy). According to this hypothesis, Singapore's fertility may be 10–25 % higher than it would have been without the policies that have been introduced.

Both these assumptions are extremely crude, but at least they provide hypotheses that can guide thinking about demographic impacts. While there are clearly differences in the socio-cultural and economic situation of the different Asian countries, there are enough similarities to make the comparison at least plausible. As we have seen, however, the specificities in the Singapore case—for example, its multi-ethnic population and its policies toward accepting people for permanent residence—must be kept in mind in any attempt to assess the role that policy has played. For example, if only the ethnic Chinese population of Singapore is used (to control for the effect of other ethnicities, particularly the Malay, in propping up Singapore's overall fertility), the fertility differential between Singapore and other Asian cities narrows—to less than a 10 % difference, and indeed to no difference at all in the cases of Tokyo, Taipei, or Hong Kong (see Table 3.2). Clarity of interpretation is further muddled by the fact that differences in TFR between Hong Kong and the Chinese population of Singapore have shifted over the past decade. In 2001, fertility was 30 % higher among Chinese Singaporeans, around 2009 fertility was similar in both populations, and since then fertility has been higher in Hong Kong.

## What Can Other Countries Learn from the Singapore Experience?

In attempting to deal with ultra-low fertility, Singapore faces the same key problems as do Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan. In the face of remarkable improvements in women's education, changing labor markets, and the economic pressures of a neo-liberal, consumerist economy, cultural and social norms have not been adapting rapidly enough, especially as they bear on the situation of increasingly educated women. In general, the problems Singapore faces are as intractable as elsewhere. Despite ongoing attention to population policy issues and considerable modification and tinkering with policies over time, there is no clear evidence that Singapore's policies have had much impact on fertility rates.

Perhaps one message to emerge is that policies bearing on fertility need to be seen as part of family policy, as they are in most European countries. Whether or not they have much impact on fertility, they can be considered successful if they make life better for families. In this context, some of the proposals that the Association of Women for Action and Research (AWARE) prepared in advance of the 2013 policy changes deserve mention (AWARE 2012). One recommendation was to convert paid childcare leave into leave for the care of dependents, who may include older children or elderly parents. Another was to widen access to childcare subsidies, motherhood benefits, and housing benefits to cover all parents, whether married or single, working or stay-at-home (eliminating the current discrimination against unwed mothers). AWARE noted that "the current exclusion of unmarried parents from certain housing benefits, parental leave, subsidies and bonuses are [sic] not only unfair but they hurt the families who most need the support."

Extended (and increasingly, permanent) singlehood is a key contributing factor to "ultra-low fertility" in East Asian societies, given that very few children are born outside marriage. For this reason, Singapore's experience with pro-marriage policies might usefully be examined by other countries.

Feedback from research in Singapore (Sun 2012) has shown that there has been a lack of communication and discussion of policies among the citizenry. Over time, however, consultation has increased, particularly in preparation for the 2013 policy changes.<sup>11</sup> Broadening current channels of communication and initiating new approaches to outreach will enhance policy formulation and implementation.

South Korea could explore policies beyond tax-rebates to offer some form of cash payment that would benefit children more directly. Singapore implemented the Baby Bonus in 2000, but South Korea has apparently been unable to implement a similar direct cash reward system due to budget constraints (Suzuki 2008, p. 38). Measures to ease re-entry into the labor force following periods of leave related to

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<sup>11</sup> During a four-month consultation period prior to the announcement of the Enhanced Marriage and Parenthood Package in January 2013, the National Population and Talent Division received more than 800 items of feedback from community organizations, employers, and members of the public.

childcare (McDonald 2002, p. 440) should be considered by all the countries under discussion, and more research is needed on the provision of child-friendly environments.

In all these countries, insufficient attention has been paid to housing issues as a factor influencing marriage and family formation. While only in Singapore does housing policy actively and deliberately foster marriage by discriminating against singles, the housing situation in other large East Asian cities may *de facto* be encouraging marriage. In fact, singles are discriminated against in the housing market in other cities such as Tokyo. “Within the Japanese housing system, choices for the unmarried are both limited and limiting” (Ronald and Nakano 2012, p. 462), with many young singles living in capsule-like rental dwellings. But the poor housing choices facing singles has not prevented the continued rise of singlehood. Of course, in East Asia, singles are expected to live in the family home until marriage, but in the past marriage was universal and occurred at much younger ages than today. The notion that young adults will avoid marriage and continue to live with their parents was the basis for the term “parasite singles” in Japan (Masahiro 1999). The issue is complex. In a city such as Hong Kong, where the average size of apartments is very small for everyone, it is hard to say who is disadvantaged most by the housing situation—singles or families. Certainly, the shortage and high cost of housing that can adequately accommodate a family of, say, three children are evident in all East Asian cities.

## Summary and Conclusions

Singapore was slow to move from anti-natalist to pro-natalist policies, but not as slow as Taiwan or South Korea. In fact, Singapore began adopting pro-natalist policies two decades before the other two countries (Singapore in 1987; South Korea and Taiwan in 2006). Despite this, Singapore experienced a sharp fertility decline from 1997 to 2003, and fertility has shown no clear sign of recovery since then. Growing government concern led to the revision and enhancement of various pro-natalist policies in 2004, 2008, and 2013. The fertility rate in Singapore has not risen appreciably, however, following these policy modifications and remains amongst the lowest in the world. The 2013 policies have not had time to have an effect, but most academic experts do not expect much. The Singapore government appears to have settled on a TFR of about 1.6 as its most optimistic target for fertility in the next few years.

Given that Singapore has adopted more comprehensive pro-natalist measures than other low-fertility countries in Asia, its experience provides little basis for expecting that pro-natalist measures will succeed elsewhere. Appropriate compari-

son in some ways is with large cities, however, rather than with countries as a whole. Compared with Hong Kong, Shanghai, Beijing, Tokyo, Seoul, Busan, and Taipei, Singapore definitely has higher fertility, although when only the Chinese Singaporean population is considered, Singapore's fertility has no edge at all over Tokyo, Taipei, or Hong Kong. Singapore does seem to have had a degree of success in limiting the trend toward ever-increasing levels of singlehood. The ways it has done this may not be relevant to other countries, however, and anyway, a levelling off of singlehood rates has not led to an increase in fertility.

Data from the Marriage and Parenthood Survey conducted in 2012 by the National Population and Talent Division (NPTD [2013a](#), [b](#)) suggest that financial costs of raising children and problems in combining work and family life are the key "crunch points" for fertility decisions. This suggests that two things may be essential if fertility levels in Singapore are to be substantially raised. The first is for the government to provide considerably higher financial incentives by raising baby-bonus payments and providing universal childcare along the French model. This would come at a substantial cost. The second requirement may be even harder to achieve, however. This would be to change the economic and social institutions, regulations affecting working conditions, and popular norms in directions that will enable work and childrearing to be more readily combined.

## Appendix

### A chronology of pro-natalist policies in Singapore

| Policy area                  | Pro-natalist policies as of about 1987 "Have three or more if you can afford it"                                                                                                                                                                   | Policy revisions 2000 | Policy revisions 2004 "Singapore: A great place for families"                                                                                                                                                                          | Policy revisions 2008                                                                                                                                                                                   | Policy revisions 2013 |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>A Monetary incentives</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                       |
| <b>A.1 Income tax relief</b> | Income Tax Relief: Introduced in 1988; S\$750 per child for first two children, S\$500 (later increased to S\$750) for third child. From 1989, amount was changed to S\$1,500 for the first four children                                          | Unchanged             | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Qualifying Child Relief (QCR) and Handicapped Child Relief (HCR) replace Income Tax Relief: Working parents can claim S\$4,000 per child for all children under QCR or S\$5,500 per child under HCR     | Unchanged             |
|                              | Enhanced Child Relief: Working mothers could claim 5 % of earned income for first child, 10 % for second, 15 % each for third and fourth child. The maximum amount was S\$10,000 per child, and the eligibility criterion was 5 GCE O-Level passes | Unchanged             | Working Mother's Child Relief replaces Enhanced Child Relief: Working mothers could claim 5 % of earned income for first child, 15 % for second, 20 % for third, 25 % for fourth. The maximum amount was raised to S\$25,000 per child | Working Mother's Child Relief: Working mothers could claim 15 % of earned income for first child, 20 % for second, 25 % for third and subsequent children. Maximum amount raised to S\$50,000 per child | Unchanged             |

|                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                      | In 1989, the tax relief amount was raised to 15 % of earned income for second child, 20 % for third, 25 % for fourth. The maximum amount was raised to S\$15,000 per child                                                                         | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                | Unchanged                                                                                                                                       | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| A.2 Tax rebates                      | Tax rebate of S\$20,000 for third child in 1987, extended to fourth child in 1989                                                                                                                                                                  | Second-Child Tax<br>Rebate: Offered for second child on a sliding scale from S\$20,000 if child born before mother turned 28 to S\$5,000 if born before mother turned 31 | Parenthood Tax<br>Rebate: S\$10,000 for second child and S\$20,000 for third and fourth child. The age requirement for second birth was removed | New Parenthood Tax<br>Rebate: S\$5,000 for first child, S\$10,000 for second, and S\$20,000 per child for all subsequent children                                                                                                                                               |
|                                      | Delivery and hospitalization expenses for fourth child offset against parents' earned income. Maximum amount capped at S\$3,000                                                                                                                    | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                | Unchanged                                                                                                                                       | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| A.3 Child- and infant-care subsidies | Childcare Subsidy: For children of working mothers: A monthly subsidy was offered of S\$100 for each of first three children under age 7 who attended full-day childcare. The subsidy was paid directly to childcare center rather than to parents | Childcare Subsidy for Non-Working Mothers: A monthly subsidy of S\$75 was introduced for children of non-working mothers enrolled in childcare centers                   | Unchanged                                                                                                                                       | Increased Childcare Subsidy (age 19 months–7 years): For working mothers, the subsidy offered was increased to a maximum of S\$300/month. For non-working mothers, the amount was increased to S\$150/month                                                                     |
|                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                 | Families with monthly household incomes of S\$7,500 or below are eligible for an Additional Subsidy, and lower-income families could receive more. Larger families with many dependents can choose to have their Additional Subsidy computed on a per capita income (PCI) basis |

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| Policy area                                                                                 | Pro-natalist policies as of about 1987 "Have three or more if you can afford it"                                                                                   | Policy revisions 2000                                                                                                                                                               | Policy revisions 2004 "Singapore: A great place for families"                                                                                                                                                                             | Policy revisions 2008                                                                                                                     | Policy revisions 2013                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                             | n.a.                                                                                                                                                               | Infant Care Subsidy: Given to working mothers with infants age 2–18 months enrolled in childcare centers. Subsidy ranged from \$S150/month for full day to \$S75/month for half day | Increased Infant Care Subsidy increased to \$S400/month for full-day care                                                                                                                                                                 | Increased Infant Care Subsidy: Subsidy increased to \$S600/month for all children                                                         | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| A.4 Use of Medisave Accounts (medical savings accounts within Central Provident Fund (CPF)) | Medisave for delivery and hospitalization charges; Payment of delivery and hospital charges for third child can be made from Medisave account; maximum is \$S3,000 | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                           | Use of Medisave for maternity extended to fourth child: Can be used for pre-delivery and delivery medical expenses for fifth child onwards, provided parents have combined Medisave balance of at least \$S15,000 at the time of delivery | Medisave Maternity Package: Parents may withdraw up to \$S450 from Medisave for pre-delivery medical expenses for the first four children | Introduction of Medisave Grant for Newborns: CPF Medisave account opened for each citizen newborn, with a Medisave grant of \$S3,000; first \$S1,500 deposited after birth registration, second \$S1,500 deposited in the following year, provided the child remains enrolled in MediShield or a Medisave-approved Integrated Shield Plan |

|                                    |                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                    | Accouchement fees for post-partum sterilization in government hospital: Waived after third or higher-order birth                                                       | Unchanged                                                                                                            | Medisave can be used for expenses associated with assisted conception procedures. Withdrawal limit raised from S\$4,000 to S\$6,000 for first three cycles                                                                        | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                            | Introduction of MediShield Coverage for Congenital and Neonatal Conditions: Newborns covered under MediShield from birth with no underwriting, including for congenital and neonatal conditions, so long as their parents do not opt them out |
| A.5 Maid Levy relief and reduction | Foreign-Maid Levy Relief for Working Mothers: In 1990, income-tax relief equal to two times annual foreign-maid levy was introduced. This was only for working mothers | Unchanged                                                                                                            | Maid Levy Concession: Monthly maid levy reduced from S\$345 to S\$250 per foreign maid for families with children under 12 or elderly persons age 65 and above. This concession was capped at two foreign workers at any one time | Foreign Domestic Worker Levy Concession: Monthly maid levy reduced to S\$170 per foreign maid for families with children under 12 or elderly persons age 65 and above. Then further reduced to S\$95 | Rebate given on foreign domestic worker levy increased from S\$95 to S\$145 for households with a child below 12, an elderly family member, or a family member with a disability                                                              |
| A.6 Cash benefits                  | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                   | Baby Bonus: S\$3,000 cash given to parents for second child and S\$6,000 for third child. This was paid over 6 years | Baby Bonus: Extended to include first and fourth child. Parents receive S\$3,000 cash for first and second child, S\$6,000 for third and fourth child. Cash given in five instalments within 18 months of child's birth           | Baby Bonus: Parents receive S\$4,000 for first and second child                                                                                                                                      | Enhanced Baby Bonus scheme: Parents receive S\$6,000 cash for first and second child and S\$8,000 for third and fourth child; cash given within 12 months of child's birth                                                                    |

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| Policy area                      | Pro-natalist policies as of about 1987 "Have three or more if you can afford it" | Policy revisions 2000                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Policy revisions 2004 "Singapore: A great place for families"                                                         | Policy revisions 2008                                                                                                                                                                           | Policy revisions 2013                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                  | n.a.                                                                             | Children Development Account (CDA): Co-savings arrangement to be used for childcare or child development; government matches savings up to S\$6,000 for second child, S\$12,000 for third; parents can save into CDA and use CDA funds until end of year when child turns 6. Savings may be used for all children | Children Development Account (CDA): Government matches savings up to S\$12,000 for fourth child                       | Children Development Account (CDA): Government matches savings up to S\$6,000 for first and second child, up to S\$12,000 for third and fourth child, up to S\$8,000 for fifth child and beyond | Children Development Account (CDA): Parents can save into CDA and use CDA funds until end of year when child turns 12 |
| A.7 Grandparent caregiver relief | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Working mothers can claim S\$3,000 relief if their parents or parents-in-law take care of their children below age 12 | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                       | Unchanged                                                                                                             |

|                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| B Housing incentives through Housing and Development Board (HDB) and Central Provident Fund (CPF) | Public Housing Upgrades for Three-Child Families: Rules altered to make it easier for families with a third child to sell their three-room or larger apartment and buy a bigger one | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                              | Public Housing for Newly-weds: Down payment for the purchase of a four-room apartment can be made in two stages, 10 % to be paid when signing the agreement and another 10 % when taking possession | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | CPF Housing Top-Up Grant for Singles Getting Married: When they decide to marry, singles who previously received government housing grant may receive top-up to match amount given to couples | Third Child Priority: 5 % of available apartments set aside for families with more than two children; included in HDB first balloting round <sup>a</sup> | Parenthood Priority: Proportion of apartments set aside for married couples with children (including those expecting a child) who have not previously applied or been given priority for HDB apartments |
|                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| C Education                                                                                       | Primary school registration: Previous disincentives against third and higher-order births removed                                                                                   | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                         | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                           | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                     | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                | Parenthood Provisional Housing: First-time married couples may rent an apartment from HDB at an affordable rate while awaiting completion of their new apartment                                        |
| D Work-family balance                                                                             | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                | Working mothers may take 8 weeks paid maternity leave for first three children (previously available for first two children only); paid by government (rather than employer); capped at S\$20,000 | Paid maternity leave extended up to fourth child; increased from 8 to 12 weeks for first four births                                                                                                | Paid maternity leave increased from 12 to 16 weeks. For first and second child, first 8 weeks paid by employer, second 8 weeks paid by government, capped at S\$20,000. For third and higher-order births, full 16 weeks paid by government, capped at S\$40,000 | Working fathers may take 1 week of their wives' 16 weeks paid maternity leave, subject to agreement of the wife. Also known as Shared Parental Leave                                          | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                               |

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| Policy area                | Pro-natalist policies as of about 1987 "Have three or more if you can afford it" | Policy revisions 2000 | Policy revisions 2004 "Singapore: A great place for families"                                       | Policy revisions 2008                                                                                                                                                                         | Policy revisions 2013                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| D.2 Paid paternity leave   | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                  | n.a.                                                                                                | n.a.                                                                                                                                                                                          | Paternity Leave: Working fathers may take 1 week of paid paternity leave                                                                                                                                             |
| D.3 Paid childcare leave   | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                  | Two days per year of employer-paid childcare leave for each working parent with a child under age 7 | Increased to 6 days per year for each working parent                                                                                                                                          | In addition, 2 days per year for each working parent with a child age 7–12                                                                                                                                           |
| D.4 Adoption leave         | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                  | Four weeks adoption leave paid by government on recommendation of employer                          | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                     | Offer of adoption leave made mandatory for mothers of adopted children below 12 months                                                                                                                               |
| D.5 Unpaid childcare leave | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                  | n.a.                                                                                                | Each parent may take 6 days a year of unpaid childcare leave for each child under age 2                                                                                                       | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| D.6 Maternity protection   | n.a.                                                                             | n.a.                  | n.a.                                                                                                | Employer required to pay maternity-leave benefits if employee is dismissed without sufficient cause within the last 6 months of pregnancy or retrenched within the last 3 months of pregnancy | Enhanced Maternity Protection for Pregnant Employees: Working mothers eligible for maternity leave benefits if they are dismissed without sufficient cause or retrenched within the full duration of their pregnancy |

|                                                    |      |      |                                                                                                                                               |           |                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------|------|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| D.7<br>Government-<br>paid<br>maternity<br>benefit | n.a. | n.a. | n.a.                                                                                                                                          | n.a.      | Working mothers who are not eligible for maternity leave may receive government-paid maternity benefit if they have been employed at least 90 days in the 12 months before childbirth |
| D.8<br>“Work-Life<br>Works!” fund                  | n.a. | n.a. | S\$10 million fund; private-sector employers may receive grants to defray cost of measures to help employees achieve better work-life harmony | Unchanged | Unchanged                                                                                                                                                                             |

Adapted from Sun (2012); Yap (2009); updated based on NPTD (2013a, b).

<sup>a</sup>This means that they may cast their vote in the first balloting round for an apartment. There are multiple rounds, and families without priority have to wait their turn

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